

REVIEW

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	MADE WITH	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
10 verified	Bullets	Grounded v4.0.0	Crossref	1 Sep 2026

SUMMARY

Bans usually reduce phone access during school. Better grades and mental health do not follow reliably: some studies find benefits, others find no change, and a few suggest social costs. Schools should treat a ban as a testable policy, not a guaranteed cure.

01 Bans change access more reliably than total use

» Across 30 English schools, restrictive policies cut reported school-time phone use by **0.67 hours per day**, yet overall weekday and weekend use did not differ.¹

» This gap matters: taking a phone away during lessons can remove an immediate distraction even when students shift their use to another time.^{2,1}

» Figure 1 separates the immediate change from the later outcomes, showing why less access should not be read as proof of better grades or wellbeing.^{1,3}



Figure 1. Phone access falls, but downstream benefits are not guaranteed. Restrictive policies can change school-time access quickly. Academic and wellbeing studies then split across positive, null, and possibly adverse findings; the open bracket marks that a ban is not a universal benefit.^{4,3,1,5}

02 Grade gains appear in some settings, not others

- » A four-city English comparison linked bans to higher test scores, especially among previously low-achieving students, and a Spanish regional study found mathematics and science gains in one of two regions.^{2,6}
- » A study covering **1,086 Swedish schools** found no improvement in grades or national mathematics tests, while the recent English school comparison also found no attainment advantage.^{7,1}
- » A rapid review of five quantitative studies estimated a small average benefit across academic and social outcomes.⁴
- » A 22-study scoping review found no randomized trials, widely differing policies and outcomes, and more than half of the evidence unpublished.⁸

03 Mental-health and social findings are mixed too

- » An emulated South Australian trial of 1,062 students linked the ban to small reductions in distress and negative mood, without a gain in positive mood.⁹

- » The 30-school English study found no difference in wellbeing, anxiety, or depression.¹
- » A one-month South Australian study found no change in school belonging or academic engagement.³
- » Across 1,398 Dutch adolescents, full rather than classroom-only bans did not improve wellbeing or bullying and were linked to weaker teacher connectedness and, among girls, lower school belonging.⁵
- » Bullying also resists a simple verdict: recorded incidents fell in the Spanish study, while bullying declined in both Australian groups and did not differ between full and partial Dutch bans.^{6,3,5}

04 Implementation is part of the intervention

- » Thirty English schools used different storage rules, exceptions, and enforcement; students, staff, and leaders also disagreed about support and compliance.¹⁰
- » In South Australia, **87%** initially reported following the rule, but older students and heavier social-media users were less compliant.³

>> A rule can look the same on paper while storage, exceptions, staff consistency, and student workarounds create a different school day.^{10,3}

>> Figure 2 follows the rule from paper through storage and enforcement to actual access, making those hidden policy differences visible.^{10,3}

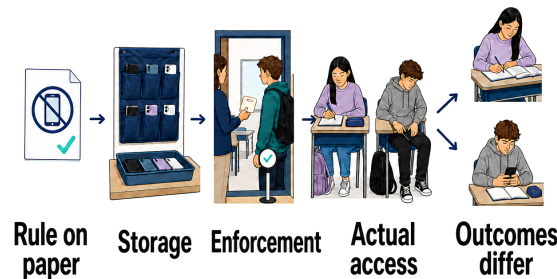


Figure 2. The rule works through storage and enforcement before outcomes can change. Policies with the same “ban” label can create different access because storage, exceptions, staff consistency, and student compliance differ. The pathway shows why the rule on paper may differ from what students actually experience; it does not identify one best policy.^{10,3,1}

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References

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